up. However, Lambton ordered a new one from England at his own expense but then spent the next six weeks painstakingly repairing the damaged equipment.

Lambton worked on the survey till he died of tuberculosis, in the field, in 1823. His crumbling grave was recently rediscovered by the writer John Keay in the village of Hinganghat, fifty miles south of Nagpur. His theodolite is in better condition and is now housed in the Survey of India headquarters in Dehradun. Less than half of the project had been completed when Lambton died. Fortunately, he was succeeded by the equally dedicated George Everest. By the time Everest retired and returned to England in 1843, the Great Arc had been extended well into the Himalayas. He built a bungalow for himself at Hathipaon, near the hill-station of Mussourie. Its ruins still stand on a ridge commanding magnificent views of snow-capped peaks on one side and the valley of Dehradun on the other. It is merely a fifteen-minute drive from Mussourie town, followed by a ten minute walk up the hill. Just the shell of the house remains, although the roof was largely intact when I visited it in February 2011 and the fireplaces were clearly visible in the larger rooms. Everything else had been stripped bare. Yet, as one looked out of the broken window frames at the Indian land mass extending south into the far distance, one could feel the soul of the eccentric but determined Welshman hanging in the air.

Everest returned home to recognition and a knighthood, but it is unclear whether he had ever seen Peak XV. In 1849, surveyors in the eastern Himalayas took theodolite measurements of Peak XV from six different angles. By averaging the measurements, the Bengali computer Radhanath Sikdar calculated that the peak was 29,000 feet high. He rushed into the office of Everest's successor, Andrew Waugh, and is said to have blurted out, 'Sir, I have discovered the highest mountain in the world'. The problem was that the learned scholars of that time would have dismissed the idea of a mountain that was over 25,000 feet. They would be especially suspicious of a rounded-out figure like 29,000. Therefore, the surveyors arbitrarily added two feet to the calculation and for decades geography textbooks